which the Northern elites would set an agenda for the rest. One of the leaked documents suggests that the US is applying 'great pressure' on the countries to cut through the divergence of opinion on questions of intellectual property, forcing Southern countries to bow the knee before Western patents. In the debate around 'investment', one of the documents shows, 'the United States has shown no flexibility on its proposal'. The outcome of these 'negotiations' is typically a victory for the West, whose pressure continues to be overwhelming, and thereafter economies of the South are subordinated by rules to Western advantage.

The record of hope is mixed. On the one side there is the collapse of the Arab Spring – it has devolved into the desolation of Egypt and the bloodletting of Iraq–Syria. Elections in Tunisia are no antidote to the victory of the counterrevolution across the Arabic-speaking lands. On the other side there remain the experiments in Latin America where, despite great challenges, popular democracy continues to be incubated. The weakened US embargo of Cuba and the possibility of a ceasefire in Colombia are only the latest indicators of the continued ebb and flow of the Pink Tide.

The most positive outcome of the Pink Tide was the creation of an alternative trade structure, the Bolivarian Alternative for the Americas, ALBA. Its 2004 declaration contained important principles for a just world trade order – solidarity, cooperation, respect for sovereignty and uneven development. These ideas emerge out of a half-century of struggle by the South to forge a more just alternative to the Western-driven 'development'.

But the undue optimism of the BRICS states that they would be able to diversify the world order simply by their presence has fallen short and pressure to forge an alternative order has been blocked. Instead, the powerhouses of the BRICS set aside the ALBA-type approach to secure the mere entry of themselves into the 'international' institutions. China might occasionally propose a 'mutual benefit' approach, but it is unlikely to push for radical ideas when it takes its seat at the World Bank or World Trade Organisation. There, neoliberal orthodoxy rules. Old ideas such as South–South cooperation have come to mean Southern multinational corporations 'cooperating' with Southern countries, rather than the formation of a trade and development regime that privileges wellbeing over profit.

The real alternative, of ALBA, promises human and environmental wellbeing above profit. But the South American states need the BRICS bloc to put their heft behind such a proposal on the global stage. The politics of such a manoeuvre is currently nowhere to be seen.